Black Fish Documentary Mobilizes SeaWorld Activists

Organization Overview

SeaWorld is a theme park chain and rehabilitation center focused on the ocean and its creatures. In their 2013 annual report SeaWorld Entertainment described themselves this way "We are a leading theme park and entertainment company delivering personal, interactive and educational experiences that blend imagination with nature and enable our customers to celebrate, connect, with and care for the natural world we share" (Swann, 2020). In the United States, there are three SeaWorld locations, with the flagship being in Orlando, Florida. Each park features roller coasters, animal shows, and displays. SeaWorld Entertainment, Inc.'s zoological collection comprises about 86,000 animals. This is made up of 78,000 fish and 8,000 marine and terrestrial animals. SeaWorld's 29 killer whales in 2016 were the largest such group in human care. In the 51-year history of their breeding program, 31 killer whales were produced. The parks are owned by United Parks and Resorts, while SeaWorld is a publicly traded company. Each site encompasses approximately 200 acres.

SeaWorld was founded in 1964 in San Diego, California, by George Millay, Milt Shedd, Ken Norris, and David DeMott. Since its inception, the organization has expanded from a single park to multiple theme parks across the United States. SeaWorld's mission is to inspire visitors to safeguard animals and support conservation efforts through rehabilitation centers, research initiatives, and expert animal care. SeaWorld carried the public image of a respected marine zoological institution, yet concerns about animal welfare were already circling. The company experienced a significant reputation shift, though, after the 2013 documentary Blackfish, which prompted a focus on animal rescue, conservation education, and a move away from orca shows and breeding programs.

Public Relations Issue

Tilikum was a male orca captured off the coast of Iceland who was subsequently transferred to SeaWorld Orlando, where he spent most of his life performing and breeding. In February 2010, Dawn Brancheau, a highly experienced SeaWorld trainer with over 15 years at the park, was working with Tilikum during a "Dine with Shamu" show in Orlando. Following the performance, while she was on a platform near the water, Tilikum suddenly grabbed her by her ponytail and pulled her into the pool. The orca held her underwater, shaking her violently. Despite immediate emergency response efforts by staff, they were unable to free her. Dawn tragically drowned and sustained severe traumatic injuries, including blunt-force trauma that ultimately led to her death. The news of Dawn Brancheau's death rapidly became a significant national story and attracted the interest of documentarian Gabriela Cowperthwaite. Gabriela sought to understand how such a tragedy could occur at a place marketed as safe, family-friendly entertainment and be perpetrated by an exceptionally intelligent sentient animal. She created the film *Blackfish* to show why killer whales should not be in captivity. The film revealed the psychological and physical toll of captivity on orcas, emphasized safety dangers for trainers, and questioned the ethical aspects of marine parks. Tilikum's story was also focused on, which argued that confinement and stress contributed to his aggression and poor welfare. Tilikum's life and death in 2017 symbolized the broader debate over marine mammal captivity and played a central role in shifting public opinion and SeaWorld's policies on animal shows and breeding.

After *Blackfish* was released, SeaWorld faced extreme backlash, and its reputation plummeted. This was a clear crisis and reputational threat, as it forced SeaWorld to make significant policy changes, including ending orca breeding and altering its shows. Activist groups from all over the world, such as People for the Ethical Treatment of Animals (PETA), called out

SeaWorld to stop taking animals from the wild and using them in shows at the park. PETA used its channels to publicize *Blackfish* and partnered with CNN to promote home-viewing parties for the film's airing. PETA also had a website called SeaWorld of Hurt that highlighted the plight of captive Orcas at SeaWorld. Blackfish not only grabbed the attention of activist groups but also millions of people worldwide on social media. According to Twitter's blog, 67,673 tweets about CNN's airing of Blackfish were viewed by 7.3 million people, making it a trending topic in the U.S. SeaWorld usually hosts musical artists, but after Blackfish aired, several artists canceled their upcoming concerts at SeaWorld.

SeaWorld's reputational damage was significant because it hurt public trust and its brand image. This led to reduced attendance and revenue. The organization also faced more protests, boycotts, and backlash from celebrities. Additionally, lawmakers and regulators began scrutinizing marine mammal practices more closely. SeaWorld's customers, employees, investors, and regulators were all affected by this. As SeaWorld earns less money, its ability to pay those involved with the organization diminishes. SeaWorld's ability to sustain its operations was at significant risk.

Media Use According to the PESO Model

SeaWorld's initial response to this was to send a critique to around 50 movie critics before the film *Blackfish's* release. This critique claimed that the film was dishonest, misleading, and scientifically inaccurate. After the film's release, SeaWorld's organization used various media within the PESO framework to address the situation. They used paid media by initiating a multimillion-dollar advertising campaign, titled "Truth About Blackfish," to counter claims made by the documentary. The campaign included print, television, and digital advertisements emphasizing animal care, conservation initiatives, and trainer–orca relationships. Additionally,

paid placements such as full-page advertisements in newspapers, including The New York Times, were utilized to directly uphold and defend the organization's reputation. Earned media was utilized through conducting media interviews and issuing press releases to contest the accuracy of Blackfish. Efforts were made to enhance credibility by emphasizing scientific collaborations and conservation initiatives, although these messages were frequently overshadowed. The organization utilized shared media through various social media platforms, including Twitter, Facebook, and YouTube, to promote pro-SeaWorld content and address critics. It also created hashtags and video series that feature veterinarians and trainers demonstrating their care for animals. Lastly, SeaWorld utilized owned media through its channels, including dedicated sections on its official website, to verify the accuracy of Blackfish and to communicate SeaWorld's perspective. The organization issued official press releases concerning safety policies, animal welfare initiatives, and investments in rescue and rehabilitation programs. Furthermore, SeaWorld developed educational content for blogs and video platforms to highlight its conservation efforts and new strategic directions, such as the phased discontinuation of orca breeding programs.

Tactics Other than PESO Implemented

To tackle this reputational crisis, SeaWorld has to use tactics other than the PESO model to address the situation and build back its reputation. The main alternative tactic they used was policy changes. SeaWorld ended its killer whale breeding program in and began to phase out theatrical shows in 2016. This tactic was necessary for SeaWorld to rebuild its reputation and was very effective. It showed that SeaWorld was trying to grow and work towards providing its animals with better care. SeaWorld also used community outreach by offering behind-the-scenes tours and educational programs to appear more transparent. This was effective because it allowed

those who may not believe that SeaWorld is changing its treatment behind the scenes to see the changes for themselves. This helps SeaWorld rebuild its reputation as a transparent and honest organization.

Key Messages

After Blackfish was released, SeaWorld communicated many different messages to the public about the organization and what it stands for. The first message they communicated was that *Blackfish* was false and misleading. This message was clear but not ethical, given that much of the film's information was factual. Critics felt like this message was dismissive and focused more on protecting SeaWorld's brand rather than addressing audience concerns. The public was not receptive to this message as they felt like the tone of these messages were mainly defensive and corporate right after, as seen in "The Truth About Blackfish" campaign, but later messages became more sympathetic and focused on reform, emphasizing conservation and transparency. These later messages emphasized that SeaWorld was taking action to change its policies and learn from its past mistakes. They implemented the new slogan "Real. Amazing" and spoke publicly about their decision to end orca breeding, according to SeaWorld Entertainment, Inc. (2015). These messages were clear but not consistent, as they are a completely different tone from SeaWorld's initial messages to the public. They were audience-centered as they addressed the issues their audience was concerned about, proving that they are willing to take action.

Evaluation

Overall, I believe that SeaWorld did not handle this issue effectively at first, but then showed growth by shifting the tone of their messages and taking action to provide their animals with better care. Their initial PR response was timely as they addressed the film *Blackfish* before it was even released. This was strategic but not ethical, as their responses avoided addressing

many of the issues talked about in the film. It did not demonstrate accountability or transparency. This worried stakeholders, as the public was quick to claim that SeaWorld was being dismissive and not owning up to its mistakes initially. SeaWorld's goal with this message was to decrease the credibility of *Blackfish,* but this message failed to do so. I believe that SeaWorld could have handled this issue better by having their initial message be apologetic and state that they are actively working to change their policies. After they do this, they can go through the film's claims and dispute the ones that are false or misleading.

SeaWorld's later handling of the issue was a step in the right direction, as they took more accountability and worked towards changing their policies. Ending their Orca breeding program was the most effective step they took. According to NBC News, "SeaWorld has been listening, and we're changing," the company said in a statement. Society is changing and we're changing with it. SeaWorld is finding new ways to continue to deliver on our purpose to inspire all our guests to take action to protect wild animals and wild places" (Jamieson, 2016). This was ethical and demonstrated accountability, but it was not timely, as the end of their breeding program did not occur until almost 3 years after *Blackfish's* release. SeaWorld's goal with this message was to rebuild trust with its stakeholders and patch back its reputation as an organization that takes the safety and care of its animals seriously. This message was well received as "Naomi Rose, marine mammal scientist at the Animal Welfare Institute, said SeaWorld's decision was a monumental and important first step forward in achieving a more humane business model" (Jamieson, 2016). SeaWorld needed to take this step as "The theme park was feeling pressure from authorities. California's Coastal Commission last year approved a $100 million expansion at SeaWorld San Diego, but only on the condition that it ended captive breeding at that facility" (Jamieson, 2016). SeaWorld knew that inaction and failure to change its policies would lead to

the organization's downfall. While these PR responses helped rebuild their reputation, most people will never forget SeaWorld's controversial past. SeaWorld needs to continue to show growth and make changes in order to completely regain the trust of its stakeholders.

References

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